Twelve Ordinary Changes Worth Writing Down

In Mom's routine, in the people who help her, and around the house.

You know Mom's routine well enough to notice when something small is different. This guide names twelve ordinary things worth a dated line in a notebook and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. A change on this list doesn't mean anything is wrong, and this page won't tell you what to do about it. What a change means for Mom's health is a question for her doctor. Most of the things to notice follow the National Institute on Aging's pages for families and the Family Caregiver Alliance's pages on backups and family meetings. The rest, and the wording about what to write down, are ours.

In Mom's routine

1 Meals and the kitchen [1]

NOTICE What's in the refrigerator and the cupboards, whether she's cooking what she usually cooks, and how the shopping gets done.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, with the date. If it's different from her usual, say what the usual was.

2 Medicines and refills [1]

NOTICE Whether the medicines she takes are in the house, and who picks up the refills.

WRITE DOWN Who handles refills and pick-up, and anything that has changed. Questions about the medicines themselves go to her pharmacist or doctor.

3 Getting to places [2]

NOTICE Which trips she makes on her own, which ones need a ride, and any she has stopped making.

WRITE DOWN Each regular trip, who drives, and whether that's the same as it was last season.

4 The things she looks forward to [3]

NOTICE The card game, the church group, the garden, the friend she has lunch with: whether she's still going, and how she gets there.

WRITE DOWN What she'd name as the good parts of her week, in her words, and anything she has dropped or taken up.

5 What the phone call can't show [1]

NOTICE What you hear on the evening call, and what you'd only see in person.

WRITE DOWN The last date someone was in the house, and who it was.

In the people who help her

6 A helper's schedule [4] [5]

NOTICE A new job, a change of shift, a move, a new baby in the family.

WRITE DOWN Who, what changed, the date, and which of Mom's tasks that person does.

7 How each helper is managing [6] [4]

NOTICE A helper, yourself included, mentioning that their part is harder to fit in, or sounding worn out or short of sleep. Also “Thanks, but I'm fine” when help is offered.

WRITE DOWN What they told you, in their words, and the date. It's a note about the arrangement, not about the person.

8 Backups, asked and unasked [7]

NOTICE A name the family gives as a fill-in, and whether anyone has asked that person. Also whether anything in their own week has changed since they said yes.

WRITE DOWN The name, “agreed” or “assumed,” what they said, and the date of the conversation.

9 Who tells whom [1] [4]

NOTICE How news about Mom travels: who the neighbor would call if an appointment moved, and whether your brother would hear about it.

WRITE DOWN For each helper, who they'd tell and how. Leave a blank where nobody knows.

Around the house

10 Rooms and stairs

NOTICE Rooms or stairs she uses less than she did, and things that have moved downstairs or within easier reach.

WRITE DOWN What's different, and roughly since when. Leave the why off the page.

11 How the house is kept [1]

NOTICE Whether it looks the way she usually keeps it: the laundry, the counters, the yard.

WRITE DOWN What's different from her usual, with the date. Her usual is the yardstick, not yours.

12 The mail and the bills [2]

NOTICE The mail on the table, who opens it, and whether anything about how the bills get handled has changed.

WRITE DOWN Who handles which bills, and anything that sat unopened, with the date.

When to call instead of writing

This list is for ordinary changes, and a notebook is the right place for them. If something about Mom's physical or mental health concerns you, the National Institute on Aging's advice is to suggest a visit to her health care provider. Tell them what you noticed and when. For an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any change means, how much it matters, or whether Mom's support should change. Those are questions for Mom, her doctor and your care consultant, and they're easier to talk through with dated notes in front of everyone.

Ready for the next step?

You know which everyday changes are worth a dated line, and you've left what they mean to the people who can say. The care interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it walks through Mom's daily life area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. National Institute on Aging, Aging in Place: Growing Older at Home
3. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age
4. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning

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